



Childcare Prices Change Fast in the Early Years

A COUNTY-LEVEL LOOK AT
WEEKLY FULL-TIME
CHILDCARE PRICES IN 2018

JON STEEN

MSDS, BELLEVUE UNIVERSITY

DSC 640: DATA PRESENTATION AND
VISUALIZATION

INSTRUCTOR: BENJAMIN SCHNEIDER

MAR 8, 2026

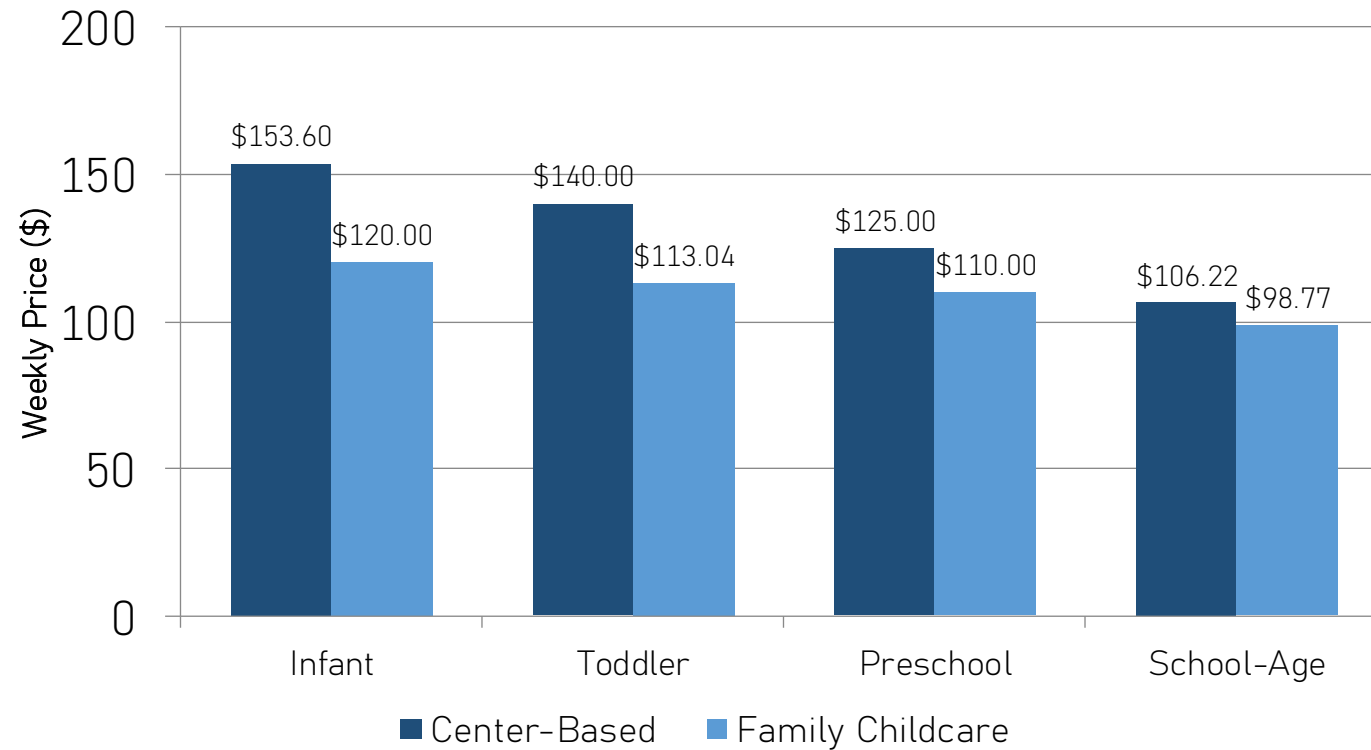
What the Data Measures

- County-level weekly childcare price estimates
- Four age groups: infant, toddler, preschool, and school-age
- Two provider types: center-based and family childcare
- Main story year shown here: 2018
- Data spans 2008 to 2018 across U.S. counties
- 3,142 counties in 2018; price data available for 2,360 (center-based) and 2,348 (family)

Note: Prices are standardized to a weekly basis, and some values are imputed or derived during dataset construction (U.S. DOL Women's Bureau, 2020).

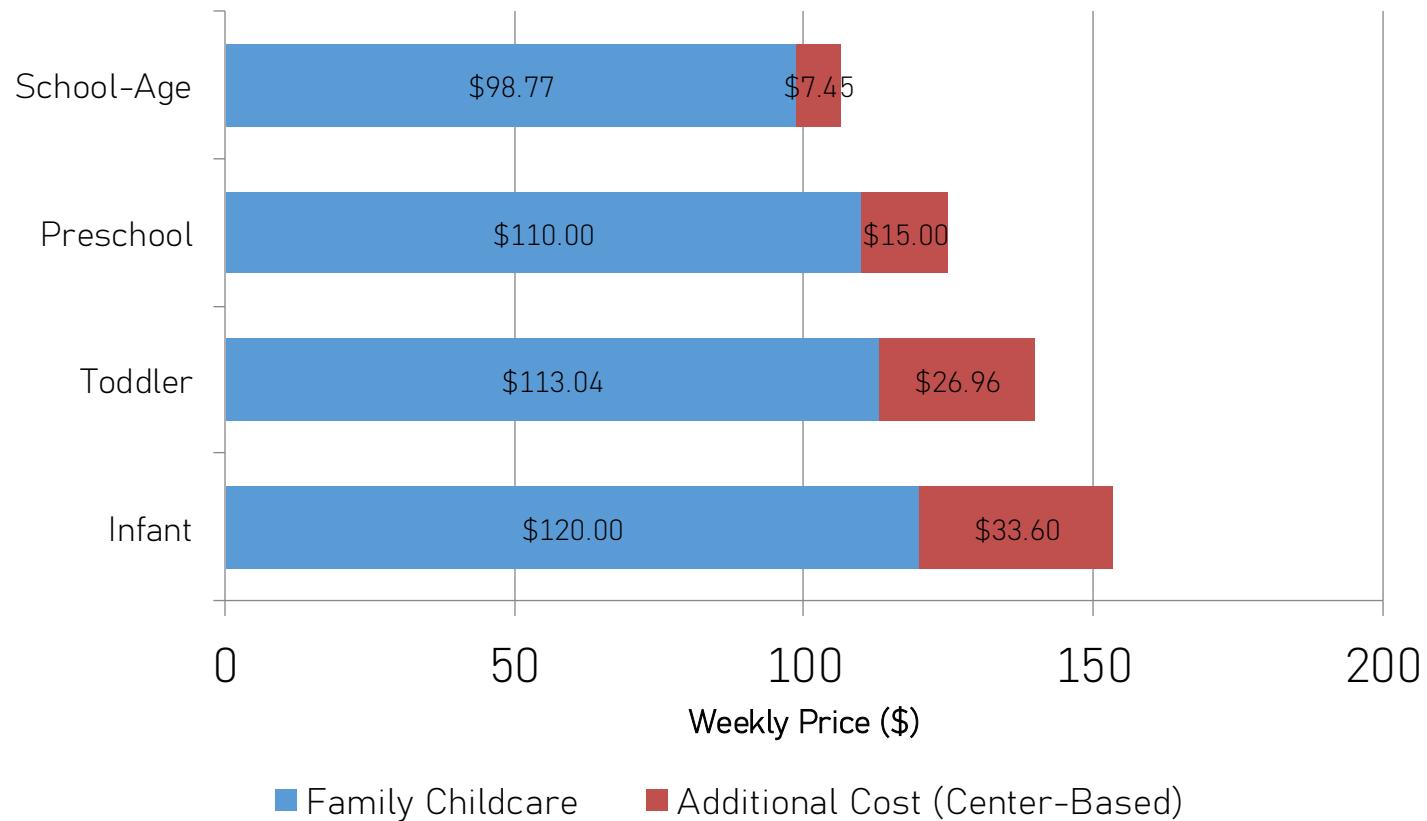


The Earliest Years Cost the Most



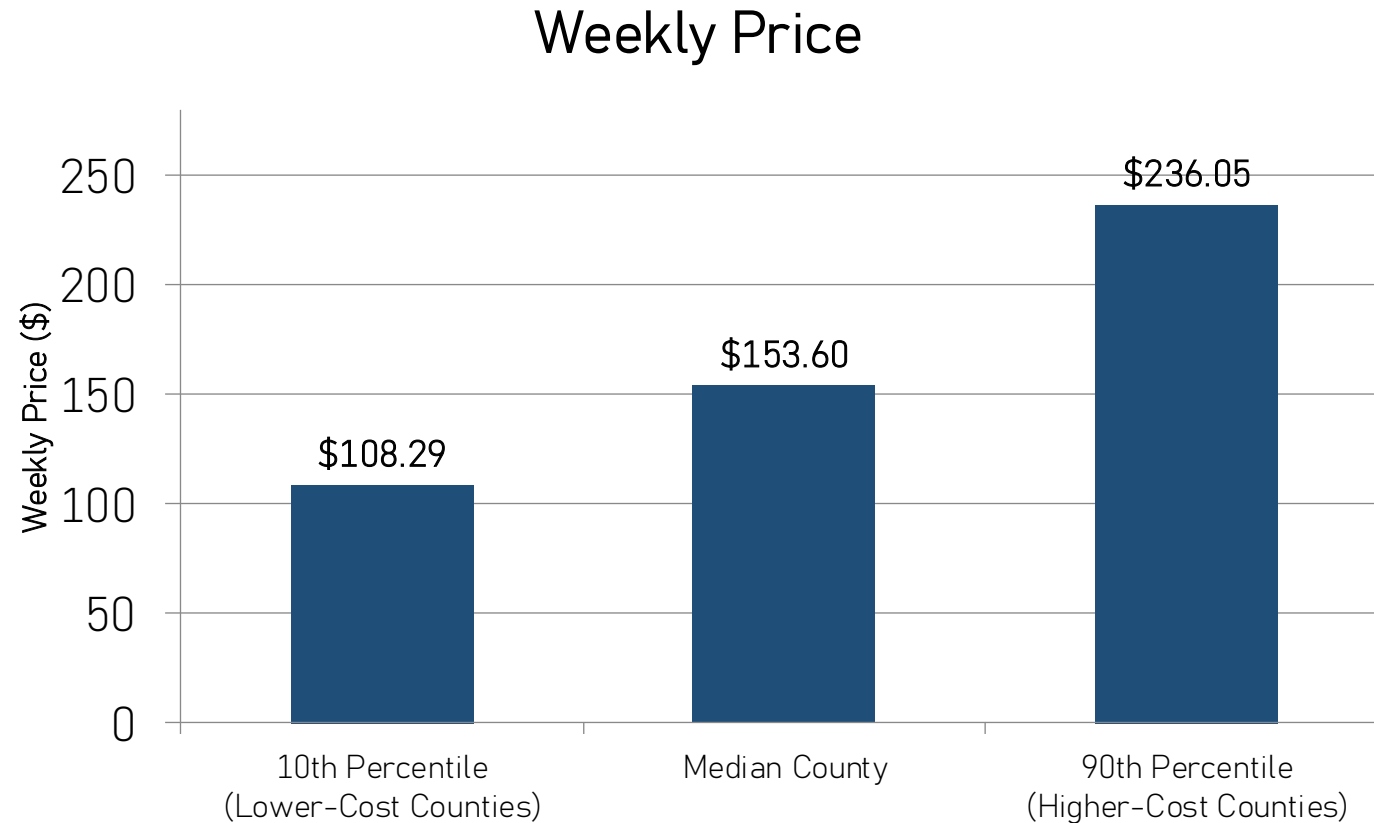
- Median weekly childcare prices by age group at the median county, 2018*

Center-Based Care Usually Costs More



- *Price gap between center-based and family childcare by age group, 2018*

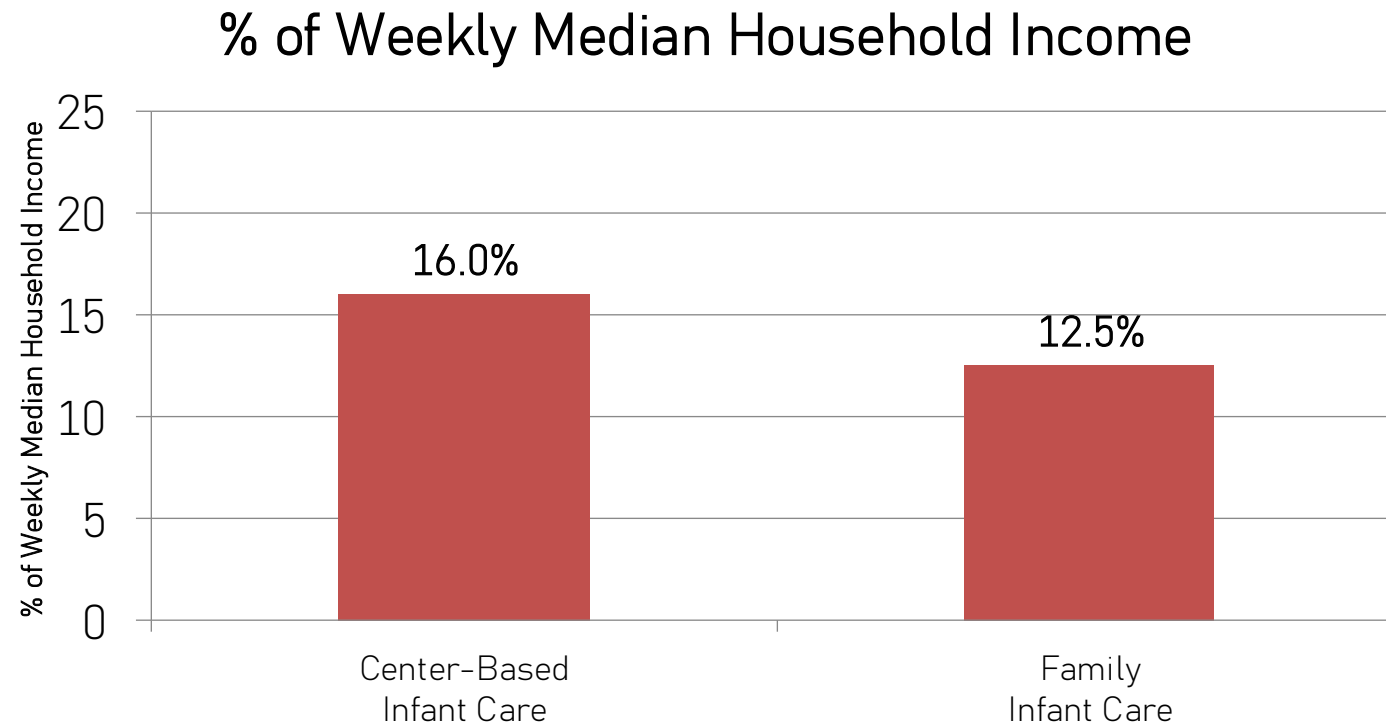
Where You Live Changes What Families Pay



- *Center-based infant care: county price distribution, 2018*

The gap between lower-cost and higher-cost counties is more than \$127 per week for center-based infant care alone.

Where You Live Changes What Families Pay



- Infant care as a share of estimated weekly median household income, 2018*

Based on county median household income (\$49,888 annually / ~\$959 weekly). This is county-level context, not a household-specific affordability calculation.

Even one childcare payment can take a meaningful share of local household earnings.

What Parents Can Do with This Information

Plan

Plan earlier for the infant and toddler years, when weekly costs are highest

Compare

Compare provider types, not just one advertised price

Use

Use county-level price data when planning work schedules and childcare transitions

Bring

Bring local numbers into conversations about flexibility, family budgets, and support needs

Knowing the local price pattern helps families plan, compare, and advocate earlier.

What Employers and Local Leaders Should Hear

When childcare prices are highest in the early years and vary widely by county, support options matter. Possible responses include:

Flexible scheduling for parents of infants and toddlers

Dependent-care benefits and pre-tax accounts

Childcare assistance programs

Stronger local attention where prices are highest

Childcare affordability acts like a work constraint for many families.

What This Dataset Does Not Show

- These data show prices, not childcare slot availability
- They do not include informal care from relatives or friends
- Some values were standardized or imputed during dataset construction
- County estimates do not equal every family's exact experience

The technical guide notes that price standardization and imputation can overestimate or underestimate true prices in some cases (U.S. DOL Women's Bureau, 2020).

Use the Dashboard for Your County

- This presentation shows the broad pattern. The dashboard lets users explore:
- State and county selection
- Year-over-year trends (2008–2018)
- Provider type comparison
- Age group breakdown
- Price percentile views
- Imputation notes and data quality flags



Dashboard QR Code
(mock)

Use local childcare price data when asking for flexibility, benefits, or support.